

Hard Edge painting

An aspect of Colour Field developed during the 1960s that became known as Hard Edge painting. The artists involved applied intense colours smoothly, emphasizing the flatness of their surfaces, but instead of blurring their coloured edges, they created sharply defined outlines, geometric contours and clean, firm lines, filled with bold units of bright colour. Influenced by Synthetic Cubism, Neo-Plasticism, Suprematism and the Bauhaus, Hard Edge artists rejected the gestural, unstructured and spontaneous approach of Abstract Expressionism.

Recognized for its economy of form, bright colours and smooth surface planes, Hard Edge painting was initially applied to the work of four artists from California: Karl Benjamin (1925–2012), John McLaughlin (1898–1976), Frederick Hammersley (1919–2009) and Lorser Feitelson (1898–1978). Although their styles varied, they were united by their use of clean lines, intense colour and smooth surfaces. Applying their paints carefully and thoughtfully, they made sure that no notion of drama or spirituality was involved.



Kenneth Noland, *Breath*, 1959